

Life in the UK

The facts you have to know

Every examinable fact from the **five chapters of the official handbook** — the only source the 24 questions are drawn from. The application process is deliberately left out: this sheet is the knowledge, not the paperwork. Facts follow the handbook, including where the country has since moved on.

4. Values and principles
11 facts

5. What is the UK?
17 facts

6. A long history
65 facts

7. Modern society
45 facts

8. Government and the law
55 facts

4 · Ch. 1 – Values and principles

Ch. 1 — Values and principles

Cap. 1 — Valori e principi

4.1 The fundamental values

- **Democracy** — representative government
- **The rule of law** — the law applies to everyone, government included
- **Individual liberty**
- **Tolerance** of those with different faiths and beliefs
- **Participation** in community life

These five values reappear verbatim in the ceremony pledge and in British public rhetoric ("British values"). Worth memorising in order.

4.2 Rights and responsibilities

Rights · Freedom of speech and expression; freedom of belief and religion; a fair trial; freedom from unfair discrimination; the right to vote (for citizens)

Responsibilities · Respect and obey the law; respect the rights of others, including their opinions; treat everyone fairly; look after yourself and your family; look after the area you live in and the environment

The handbook insists rights and responsibilities are two sides of one coin: applying for citizenship means accepting both.

4.3 Oath and pledge

Oath (or affirmation for those who do not swear on scripture): loyalty to His Majesty the King, his heirs and successors, according to law.

Pledge: "I will give my loyalty to the United Kingdom and respect its rights and freedoms. I will uphold its democratic values. I will observe its laws faithfully and fulfil my duties and obligations as a British citizen."

5 · Ch. 2 – What is the UK?

Ch. 2 — What is the UK?

Cap. 2 — Cos'è il Regno Unito

5.1 The four nations

United Kingdom · England, Scotland, Wales, **Northern Ireland** — full name: *United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland*

Great Britain · England, Scotland and Wales only (the large island)

Crown dependencies · The Channel Islands and the Isle of Man: linked to the Crown but **not part of the UK**

Overseas territories · St Helena, the Falklands, Gibraltar...: linked to the UK, not part of it

Capitals · London (UK and England), Edinburgh (Scotland), Cardiff (Wales), Belfast (Northern Ireland)

Population · The handbook cites about **62 million** (2010/2011 census); today's ONS estimate is over **69 million**. In the exam, the book's figure wins

5.2 Flags and patron saints

St David · Wales — **1 March** — daffodil and leek

St Patrick · Northern Ireland — **17 March** — shamrock

St George · England — **23 April** — rose

St Andrew · Scotland — **30 November** — thistle

5.2 Flags and patron saints *(cont.)*

• **The Union Flag** ("Union Jack") combines the cross of St George (red on white), St Andrew (diagonal white on blue) and St Patrick (diagonal red on white).

• **Wales is not represented** on the Union Flag: it was already united with England when the flag was created.

• Only 17 March and 30 November are official holidays, and only in Northern Ireland and Scotland.

5.3 Languages and currency

• **English** is the de facto official language; **Welsh** is official in Wales and taught in schools.

• **Scottish Gaelic** in the Highlands and islands; **Scots** and **Ulster Scots**; **Irish** in Northern Ireland.

• Currency: the **pound sterling (£)**, divided into 100 pence. Notes of £5, £10, £20, £50.

• **Scotland and Northern Ireland issue their own banknotes**, valid across the UK though not always accepted without argument in England.

6 · Ch. 3 – A long history

Ch. 3 — A long history

Cap. 3 — Una lunga storia

6.1 Prehistory and the Romans

10,000 years ago · Britain is still joined to the continent by a land bridge

Stone Age · **Stonehenge** (Wiltshire) and **Skara Brae** (Orkney), the best-preserved Neolithic village in northern Europe

Iron Age · The Celts; the first coins minted in Britain; hill forts such as Maiden Castle

55 BC · **Julius Caesar** invades unsuccessfully

AD 43 · Emperor **Claudius** conquers Britain, except Scotland

AD 60/61 · The revolt of **Boudicca**, queen of the Iceni: her statue stands on Westminster Bridge

AD 122 · **Hadrian's Wall**, built to keep out the Picts; now a UNESCO site

AD 410 · The Romans leave Britain to defend the Empire elsewhere

6.2 Anglo-Saxons, Vikings, Normans

5th–6th c. · Angles, Saxons and Jutes from northern Europe; Christianity spreads (St Augustine, St Columba)

Sutton Hoo · Anglo-Saxon ship burial in Suffolk, with treasure and helmet

AD 789 · First **Viking** raids from Denmark and Norway

9th c. · **Kenneth MacAlpin** unites the Scottish kingdoms

1066 · **Battle of Hastings**: **William the Conqueror**, Duke of Normandy, defeats King Harold. The **Bayeux Tapestry** tells the story

1086 · **Domesday Book**: the survey of English land

1215 · **Magna Carta**: King John accepts limits on royal power — the cornerstone of British liberties

1284 · **Statute of Rhuddlan**: Wales annexed to the English crown (formal union in 1536)

1314 · **Bannockburn**: **Robert the Bruce** defeats the English and Scotland stays independent

1337–1453 · **Hundred Years War** with France; **Agincourt 1415**, Henry V's victory

6.2 Anglo-Saxons, Vikings, Normans *(cont.)*

1348 · **Black Death**: perhaps a third of the population dies

1455–1485 · **Wars of the Roses**: York (white rose) against Lancaster (red rose). Ends at **Bosworth Field, 1485**: Henry Tudor becomes **Henry VII**

6.3 Tudors and Stuarts

Henry VIII · Breaks with Rome and founds the **Church of England** (1534). **Six wives**: Catherine of Aragon, Anne Boleyn, Jane Seymour, Anne of Cleves, Catherine Howard, Catherine Parr — “divorced, beheaded, died; divorced, beheaded, survived”

Edward VI · Protestant; introduces the **Book of Common Prayer**

Mary I · Catholic, persecutes Protestants (“Bloody Mary”)

Elizabeth I · Protestant; a long and prosperous reign; **1588: defeat of the Spanish Armada**

Mary, Queen of Scots · Catholic, flees to England, imprisoned and **executed in 1587**

1603 · **Union of the Crowns**: James VI of Scotland becomes **James I** of England

1605 · **Gunpowder Plot**: Guy Fawkes tries to blow up Parliament — remembered on **5 November**

1611 · **King James Bible**, the authorised English version

Shakespeare · 1564–1616, of Stratford-upon-Avon: the drama and poetry of the Elizabethan age

6.4 Civil War and Revolution

1642 · **Civil War** breaks out: *Cavaliers* (Royalists) against *Roundheads* (Parliamentarians)

1649 · **Charles I** executed; England becomes a republic, the *Commonwealth*

Oliver Cromwell · **Lord Protector**; a brutal campaign in Ireland

1660 · **Restoration**: Charles II returns to the throne

1660 · The **Royal Society** is founded, the oldest surviving scientific society

1665 / 1666 · The **Great Plague** and the **Great Fire of London**; St Paul's rebuilt by Christopher Wren

1679 · **Habeas Corpus Act**: no arbitrary detention

1688 · **Glorious Revolution**: William of Orange and Mary replace James II with no bloodshed in England

1689 · **Bill of Rights**: Parliament must meet regularly and consent to taxes — **constitutional monarchy** begins

1707 · **Act of Union**: the **Kingdom of Great Britain** is created

1721 · **Sir Robert Walpole**, regarded as the **first Prime Minister**

1745–46 · The Jacobite rising of **Bonnie Prince Charlie**, crushed at **Culloden**; the *Highland Clearances* follow

6.5 Empire and Industrial Revolution

1801 · **Act of Union** with Ireland: the *United Kingdom of Great Britain and Ireland* is born

1805 · **Trafalgar**: Admiral **Nelson** defeats the French and Spanish fleets and dies in the battle

1815 · **Waterloo**: the **Duke of Wellington** defeats Napoleon

6.5 Empire and Industrial Revolution *(cont.)*

1807 / 1833 · Abolition of the **slave trade** and then of **slavery** across the Empire; **William Wilberforce** leads the campaign

Industrial Revolution · **Richard Arkwright** (spinning), **James Watt** (steam engine), **Isambard Kingdom Brunel** (railways, bridges, ships), **George Stephenson**

1837–1901 · **The Victorian age**: the British Empire covers a quarter of the globe

1853–56 · **Crimean War**; **Florence Nightingale** founds modern nursing

1851 · **The Great Exhibition** at the Crystal Palace, a showcase of British industry

6.6 The twentieth century

1913–1928 · **Suffragettes** led by **Emmeline Pankhurst**; in **1918** women over 30 with property win the vote; in **1928** equal voting at 21

1914–1918 · **First World War**; the **Somme, 1916**: 60,000 British casualties on the first day alone

1922 · The **Irish Free State** is created; **Northern Ireland** stays in the UK, which takes its present name

1929 · **The Great Depression**: mass unemployment

1939–1945 · **Second World War**; **Winston Churchill** Prime Minister from 1940

1940 · **Dunkirk**, the seaborne evacuation; the **Battle of Britain**, won by the RAF — “Never was so much owed by so many to so few”

6 June 1944 · **D-Day**: the Allies land in Normandy

8 May 1945 · **VE Day**, victory in Europe

Bletchley Park · **Alan Turing** and the Enigma codebreakers

6.7 Post-war to today

1942 / 1948 · The **Beveridge Report** and the founding of the **National Health Service** by **Aneurin Bevan**: care free at the point of use

1948 · The **Empire Windrush** arrives: immigration from the Caribbean and later the Indian subcontinent

1949 / 1973 · The UK is a founding member of **NATO**; joins the **EEC** in 1973

1979 · **Margaret Thatcher**, the first woman Prime Minister, in office until 1990

1998–1999 · The **Good Friday Agreement** in Northern Ireland and **devolution**: the Scottish Parliament, Welsh Assembly and Northern Ireland Assembly are created

2012 · The **London Olympic and Paralympic Games**

After the handbook. These events postdate the 2013 book and are not examinable, but they explain the country: the Scottish referendum of **2014**; the EU referendum of **2016** and leaving the Union on **31 January 2020**; the Covid-19 pandemic; the death of **Elizabeth II** in September **2022** and the coronation of **Charles III** on 6 May **2023**.

7 · Ch. 4 – Modern society

Ch. 4 — Modern society

Cap. 4 — Società moderna

7.1 Religion

• The census cited in the handbook (2011): about **59% Christian**, **25% no religion**, Muslim 4.8%, Hindu 1.5%, then Sikh, Jewish and Buddhist.

• The **Church of England** (Anglican) is the established church in England; the **monarch is its Supreme Governor** and the **Archbishop of Canterbury** its spiritual leader.

• In Scotland the national church is the **Church of Scotland**, Presbyterian, led by a **Moderator** elected annually.

• There is **no established church** in Wales or Northern Ireland.

• Freedom to practise any religion — or none — is a fundamental principle.

7.2 Festivals and traditions

25 December · **Christmas Day**: turkey lunch, Christmas pudding, the King's message

26 December · **Boxing Day**, a public holiday

31 December · **New Year's Eve**; in Scotland **Hogmanay**, a major festival, with 2 January also a holiday

March/April · **Easter**: Good Friday and Easter Monday are holidays; before it, Lent and *Shrove Tuesday* (pancake day)

5 November · **Bonfire Night**: bonfires and fireworks for Guy Fawkes's failed 1605 plot

11 November · **Remembrance Day**: red poppies and two minutes' silence at 11am

31 October · **Hallowe'en**, of ancient pre-Christian origin

Other communities · **Diwali** (Hindu and Sikh), **Eid al-Fitr** and **Eid al-Adha** (Muslim), **Vaisakhi** (Sikh), **Hanukkah** and **Yom Kippur** (Jewish)

Bank holidays · Public holidays when banks and many businesses close; dates vary across the four nations

7.3 Sport

Football · Grew from medieval England; the **Premier League**; the four nations have separate national teams

Cricket · **The Ashes**: the historic series against Australia; **Lord's** is the emblematic ground

Rugby · **Six Nations**: England, Scotland, Wales, Ireland, France, Italy

Tennis · **Wimbledon**, the world's oldest tournament, since 1877

Golf · Born in Scotland; **St Andrews** is its historic home

Horse racing · The **Grand National** at Aintree, **Royal Ascot**, the Derby at Epsom

Names · **Sir Roger Bannister** (sub-four-minute mile, 1954), **Sir Steve Redgrave** (five Olympic rowing golds), **Baroness Tanni Grey-Thompson** (Paralympics), **Sir Bradley Wiggins**, **Mo Farah**, **Jessica Ennis**, **Sir Andy Murray**

7.4 Literature and the arts

Theatre · **William Shakespeare** (Romeo and Juliet, Hamlet, Macbeth); the **Globe Theatre**; London's **West End**; **Gilbert and Sullivan**; **Andrew Lloyd Webber**; the **Edinburgh Festival Fringe**

Poetry · **Robert Burns** (Scottish, *Auld Lang Syne*, celebrated on *Burns Night*, 25 January), **William Wordsworth**, **Lord Byron**, **Dylan Thomas**; **Poets' Corner** in Westminster Abbey

7.4 Literature and the arts *(cont.)*

The novel · **Jane Austen**, **Charles Dickens**, **Thomas Hardy**, **Robert Louis Stevenson**, **Graham Greene**, **J.K. Rowling**; the **Man Booker Prize** honours the best novel of the year

Painting · **Thomas Gainsborough**, **John Constable**, **J.M.W. Turner**, the **Pre-Raphaelites**, **Henry Moore** (sculpture), **David Hockney**, **Lucian Freud**; the **Turner Prize** for contemporary art

Architecture · **Sir Christopher Wren** (St Paul's), **Inigo Jones**, **Robert Adam**, **Sir Norman Foster**, **Zaha Hadid**

Museums · The British Museum, National Gallery, Tate, Victoria and Albert: **free entry** to permanent collections

7.5 Music, cinema, TV

Classical music · **Henry Purcell**, **George Frideric Handel** (*Water Music*, *Messiah*, a naturalised Briton), **Gustav Holst** (*The Planets*), **Sir Edward Elgar** (*Pomp and Circumstance*), **Ralph Vaughan Williams**, **Sir William Walton**, **Benjamin Britten**

The Proms · The BBC's classical concert season at the **Royal Albert Hall**, since 1927; the **Last Night of the Proms** closes the summer

Music awards · The **Mercury Music Prize** (best album) and the **BRIT Awards**

Cinema · **Sir Alfred Hitchcock**, **Sir Charlie Chaplin**, **Sir David Lean**, **Sir Ridley Scott**, **Nick Park** (Wallace & Gromit); the **BAFTA** awards

TV and radio · The **BBC**, funded by the TV *licence*: it is required to watch or record live broadcasts and to use iPlayer

7.6 Science and invention

Sir Isaac Newton · Gravity and the laws of motion; the *Principia Mathematica*

Sir Alexander Fleming · Discovers **penicillin** (1928), Nobel Prize 1945

John Logie Baird · A Scot, the first **television** transmission (1926)

Sir Tim Berners-Lee · Invents the **World Wide Web** (1989–90)

Sir Frank Whittle · The **jet engine**

Crick, Watson and Franklin · The structure of **DNA** (Cambridge and King's College, 1953)

Ada Lovelace · The first computer program, with Charles Babbage

Others · **Sir Christopher Cockerell** (hovercraft), **Sir Robert Edwards and Patrick Steptoe** (IVF), **Dolly the sheep** (the first cloned mammal, Edinburgh 1996), **Alexander Graham Bell** (the telephone)

7.7 Leisure and places

• **Pubs**: central to social life. Minimum age to buy alcohol: **18**; at 16 you may drink beer or wine with a meal if accompanied by an adult (local rules vary).

• **Gardening**: a national passion; the **Chelsea Flower Show** is its landmark event.

• The **National Trust** (1895) and **English Heritage**: they protect historic houses, coastline and landscape, open to the public.

7.7 **Leisure and places** *(cont.)*

- **UNESCO** sites named: Stonehenge, Hadrian's Wall, the Giant's Causeway (Northern Ireland), Orkney, Blenheim Palace, the Dorset and East Devon Jurassic Coast.
- Places to remember: **Big Ben** (the great bell in the Elizabeth Tower), **Edinburgh Castle**, **Snowdonia**, the **Lake District**, **Loch Lomond**, the **London Eye**.

8 · Ch. 5 – Government and the law

Ch. 5 — Government and the law

Cap. 5 — Governo e legge

8.1 **The monarchy**

- The UK is a **constitutional monarchy**: the monarch is head of state, while governing power lies with Parliament and the Government.
- The monarch is **politically neutral** and expresses no party views.
- Duties: opens Parliament each year (the **State Opening**, with the King's Speech written by the Government), meets the Prime Minister weekly, gives **Royal Assent** to laws, appoints the Prime Minister.
- The monarch is **Supreme Governor of the Church of England** and **Head of the Commonwealth**.
- **Update**: the handbook describes **Elizabeth II**, queen from 1952. Since September 2022 the monarch is **Charles III**, and exam questions about "the current king" have been updated accordingly; the **Prince of Wales** is now **William**.

8.2 **Parliament**

House of Commons · **650 MPs** elected, one per constituency; the more powerful chamber because it is elected and controls money

House of Lords · Unelected: appointed **life peers**, some **hereditary peers**, and Church of England bishops. It revises and can delay legislation, but the Commons can have the final say

The Speaker · Chairs the Commons and is **politically neutral**, though an MP chosen by fellow MPs

The Crown · **Royal Assent** completes a law's passage

The Opposition · The second-largest party forms the **shadow cabinet**; its leader heads the official Opposition

Whips · Ensure party MPs vote with the line

Where · The **Palace of Westminster**, London

8.3 **Government and Prime Minister**

- The **Prime Minister** is the leader of the party able to command a majority in the Commons; lives at **10 Downing Street** with a country house at **Chequers**.
- They appoint the **Cabinet**, around twenty senior ministers: the *Chancellor of the Exchequer* (economy), *Home Secretary* (interior and immigration), *Foreign Secretary*, *Lord Chancellor* (justice).
- **Civil servants** are professional officials, **politically neutral** and appointed on merit: they stay when the government changes.
- Local government (*councils*) runs schools, waste, roads and social services, funded by **council tax** and central grants.
- The press is free and uncensored: the handbook stresses that newspapers may openly criticise the government.

8.4 **Elections and voting**

- A **general election** at least every **5 years**; the system is **first past the post**: whoever gets most votes in a constituency wins it.
- A **by-election** is held when a seat falls vacant between general elections.
- You vote at **18**; in Scotland and Wales at **16** for devolved and local elections.
- You must be on the **electoral register**: registering is a legal duty when your household is asked.
- Polling stations open **7am to 10pm**; the ballot is **secret**. You can vote by post or by proxy.
- **Update since the handbook**: since May 2023, **photo ID** is required to vote in person in Great Britain.
- Anyone can watch Commons and Lords debates from the public galleries, or contact their own MP.

8.5 **Devolution**

Scotland · The **Scottish Parliament** at Holyrood, Edinburgh: **129 MSPs**. Powers over health, education, justice and some taxes

Wales · The **Senedd Cymru / Welsh Parliament** in Cardiff: **60 members**. In the 2013 handbook it is still the *National Assembly for Wales*, renamed in 2020

Northern Ireland · The **Northern Ireland Assembly** at Stormont, Belfast: **90 MLAs**, with power-sharing government from the Good Friday Agreement

Reserved · Kept at Westminster: defence, foreign policy, immigration, monetary policy

The devolved bodies use forms of proportional representation, not first past the post.

8.6 **The justice system**

Principle · **Judges are independent** of government and interpret the law; the presumption of innocence is the rule

Minor crimes · The **Magistrates' Court** in England, Wales and Northern Ireland: unpaid volunteer *Justices of the Peace*, usually without legal training. In Scotland: the **Justice of the Peace Court**

Serious crimes · The **Crown Court** with a jury of **12** (England, Wales, Northern Ireland); in Scotland the **Sheriff Court** or High Court with a jury of **15**

Civil cases · The **County Court** for debt, contracts and divorce; the **small claims** procedure for low-value cases, without a lawyer

Top · The **Supreme Court**, since 2009, is the final court of appeal

Help · A **solicitor** for advice and paperwork; **legal aid** can cover costs for those who cannot pay

8.7 **Police and rights**

- The police must **protect the public, prevent and investigate crime** and act fairly and honestly; they answer to an elected **Police and Crime Commissioner**, and complaints go to the independent watchdog.
- The **Equality Act 2010** prohibits discrimination on grounds of age, disability, sex, pregnancy, race, religion or belief, sexual orientation, gender reassignment and marriage.
- **Domestic violence, female genital mutilation, forced marriage** and so-called "honour" crimes are serious offences: no tradition excuses them.
- Drug possession, drink-driving, carrying knives or weapons and hate crime are all criminal offences.
- Anyone needing help can turn to **Citizens Advice**, free and independent.

8.8 **Tax and civic duties**

- Your **National Insurance number** is personal and needed to work; contributions build entitlement to the state pension and some benefits.
- **Income tax** is normally deducted at source through **PAYE**; the self-employed and those with extra income file a **self assessment** return by **31 January** online.
- **Jury service** is a duty: anyone on the electoral register can be called.
- You can drive at **17** (16 for a moped); you need a valid licence, **insurance**, vehicle tax and an annual **MOT** for vehicles over 3 years old.
- Non-UK EU licences must be exchanged within the applicable time limits once you settle in the UK.

8.9 **Your role in the community**

- Serving as a **school governor**, or on a school board in Scotland; as a volunteer **magistrate**; as a **Special Constable**.
- Donating **blood** and organs; supporting charities with time or money.
- Taking part in politics: joining a party, campaigning, standing in local elections.
- Caring for the environment: recycling, cutting waste, walking or using public transport.
- The handbook's message: citizenship does not end with the certificate, it begins with participation.

8.10 **The UK and the world**

The Commonwealth · A voluntary association of countries, mostly former Empire; **the King is its Head**; it has no power over members

United Nations · The UK is a **permanent member of the Security Council**, with a veto

NATO · A collective defence alliance: an attack on one member is an attack on all

Council of Europe · The human-rights and rule-of-law body behind the **European Convention on Human Rights**: *a separate thing from the European Union*

European Union · The 2013 handbook describes the UK as a member state. **Since the handbook**: the 2016 referendum, and departure on **31 January 2020**